

Unit 6 Part B — Writing a One-sided Argumentative Essay

1. Purpose & example questions

Purpose

- To express your opinion on a **controversial** issue, arguing either for or against it
- Target audience — **students** (on the school newsletter), the **general public** (on newspapers and technology magazines)

Example questions

- *Social media does more harm than good to teenagers.*
- *Should schools ban AI chatbots from the classroom?*
- *Is the internet making us less able to concentrate?*

2. Planning your essay

Title	Choose ONE of three patterns: (1) Issue + verdict — <u>Social Media: More Harm Than Good</u> (2) Question — <u>Is Social Media Doing More Harm Than Good?</u> (3) Call to action — <u>Why We Must Rethink Social Media</u>
Introduction	1. Hook — one striking line, figure, image or short question <i>The average Hong Kong teenager now spends close to six hours a day on social media.</i> 2. Narrow the focus — link the issue to the audience <i>Social media is now ubiquitous and it quietly reshapes the way young people see themselves and one another.</i> 3. Stance — ONE side, in one sentence <i>I firmly believe that ... / It is undeniable that ...</i>
Body paragraphs 1 & 2	1. Topic sentence — a signpost + the argument itself <i>First and foremost, social media is detrimental to teenagers' mental health.</i> 2. Explain — build a cause-and-effect chain (X → Y → Z) <i>Platforms are designed to reward comparison, so users are constantly shown polished photographs of other people's lives, and they are encouraged to measure their own against them.</i> 3. Example — Findings / Real-world case / Typical process <i>Findings — "According to the US Surgeon General's 2023 advisory, adolescents who spend more than three hours a day on</i>

	<i>social media face double the risk of depression and anxiety."</i> <i>Real-world case — France has restricted phones in its middle schools since 2018 and in 2024 trialled a "digital pause", requiring pupils to hand in their phones for the whole school day. (Another: in November 2024, Australia legislated a minimum age of sixteen for social media accounts.)</i> <i>Typical process — Consider what happens when the app is opened for a five-minute break: the feed fills with classmates' holidays and prizes, an ordinary evening is set beside them, and self-doubt follows.</i> Never write these (a marker spots them instantly) • invented names ("my friend Jason", "a Form 5 student called Mary") • invented percentages ("87% of students") 4. Round off — echo your topic sentence <i>Day after day, this comparison erodes self-esteem and exacerbates the anxiety that many teenagers already carry.</i>
Body paragraph 3 (counter-argument & rebuttal)	1. Concede — state the other side briefly <i>Admittedly, ... / Some may argue that ...</i> 2. Rebut — a concrete reason why the objection fails <i>However, this argument overlooks the fact that ...</i> 3. Round off — re-affirm your stance <i>Put simply, the convenience is real but modest, while the harm compounds year after year.</i>
Conclusion	1. Restate the stance in NEW words — do not copy the introduction 2. Summarise your arguments in one line. 3. Final thought — a call to action.
Common mistakes — content and phrases DSE markers do not favour Title — "My Opinion About Social Media", "Social Media", "A Report on ...": a title must name the issue and take ONE side. Introduction — the empty opener ("Nowadays, with the development of technology, ..."; "As we all know, ...") and fence-sitting ("It has advantages and disadvantages"; "Both sides have a point"). The task demands one side. Body — the same reason repeated in three paragraphs ("it wastes time"). Give each paragraph ONE new reason: health, learning, friendship, privacy. Body — invented evidence: made-up figures ("87% of students"), made-up people ("my friend Jason"), and bare "studies show that ..." with no source. Body — a paragraph with no example at all, or an "example" that is	

really another explanation.

Counter-argument — over-conceding (“it is bad but it is also good, so we should use it properly”) leaves the reader on the other side; rebutting with “However, I do not agree” and no reason does not count as a rebuttal.

Conclusion — copying the introduction word for word, adding a new argument, or ending with “I hope you will agree with me.”

Register — “you”; chatty fillers (“in a nutshell”, “all in all”, “last but not least”); vague words (“super”, “stuff”, “a lot of things”); strings of rhetorical questions or exclamation marks.

Anywhere — memorised template sentences that would fit any question. Markers reward an answer to THIS question.

Teaching activity — plan-and-swap (25 minutes, suggested)

1. Warm-up (5 min) — project the poor examples in Section 4 and fix one aloud as a class (“super bad” → “detrimental”). Ask which words show the marker where the argument is going.

2. Plan, not write (8 min) — in pairs, give each pair ONE example question from Section 1. They fill in the plan only: title, hook, stance, two topic sentences, one labelled example per body paragraph (Findings / Real-world case / Typical process), concede + rebut, final thought.

3. Swap and check (5 min) — pairs exchange plans and tick four things: one side only? two different reasons? every example labelled and not invented? does Body 3 end on the writer’s side?

4. Report back (5 min) — three pairs read out one line; the class names any mistake it hears, comparing it with the red list above.

5. Close (2 min) — each student writes ONE sentence using a Unit 6 word from the list that they have never used before.

Short on time? 10-minute version: cover the right-hand plan column, show only the labels (Title, Hook, Stance, Topic sentence ...), and ask the class to predict each move before you reveal it.

Spare capacity? Give the strongest pair the OPPOSITE stance on the same question and let them rebuild Body 1 using a mirror example (access to information, online community, self-expression).

3. Sample writing

Question: You have read an article in a local technology magazine claiming that social media does more harm than good to teenagers. Write an essay for the magazine arguing for OR against this view. Support your view with reasons and examples. (about 400 words)

BOLD = *persuasive language*

Underlined = *linking words and signals*.

Social Media: More Harm Than Good	Title
The average Hong Kong teenager now spends close to six hours a day on social media. That time could have been spent sleeping, revising or simply talking to family. Social media is now ubiquitous, and <u>although</u> it promises connection, it quietly reshapes the way young people see themselves and one another. I firmly believe that social media does more harm than good to teenagers. <u>First and foremost</u>, social media is detrimental to teenagers' mental health. Platforms are designed to reward comparison, <u>so</u> users are constantly shown polished photographs of other people's holidays and achievements, and pushed to measure their own lives against them. The evidence is no longer in doubt: according to the US Surgeon General's 2023 advisory, adolescents who spend more than three hours a day on social media face double the risk of depression and anxiety. Day after day, this comparison erodes self-esteem and exacerbates anxiety — harm that is easy to miss <u>because</u> it feels normal. <u>Moreover</u>, the damage reaches beyond feelings into academic performance. Every notification leaves attention fragmented, making deep reading almost impossible to sustain. Late-night scrolling also delays sleep, <u>which in turn</u> undermines concentration in class. Governments have reached the same conclusion: France has restricted phones in its middle schools since 2018 and in 2024 trialled a "digital pause", requiring pupils to hand in their phones for the whole school day. When the loss is measured in attention and sleep, convenience is a poor defence. <u>Some may argue that</u> social media keeps teenagers connected and gives them a voice they would otherwise lack. <u>Admittedly</u>, a group chat can help a class organise a project, and a niche interest may find community online. <u>However</u>, these benefits are superficial when set against the costs. Connectivity available at any hour is precisely what makes it hard to switch off, and a following built on 'likes' is rarely mutual support; at best, it is a short-lived substitute for friendship. <u>Put simply</u>, the convenience is real but modest, <u>while</u> the harm	Introduction • Hook • Stance Body 1 - Argument • Topic sentence • Explanation • Example • Round off Body 2 - Argument • Topic sentence • Explanation • Example • Round off Body 3 - Counter-argument • Concede • Rebut • Round off Conclusion • Restate stance • Summarise arguments

compounds year after year. <u>In conclusion</u>, social media is not without value, yet its effects on teenagers' well-being, concentration and self-image plainly outweigh its benefits. Banning the technology would be counterproductive; the answer is a deliberate effort to curb the hours we spend online. If teenagers can learn to switch off, they will discover that the world beyond the screen deserves their attention. (400 words)	Final thought
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4. Language features — five reminders
<i>Both examples in each pair say the SAME thing. BOLD = persuasive language. <u>Underlined</u> = linking words.</i>

Reminder	✗ Poor example	✓ Upgraded example (from the sample)
Formal vocabulary <i>no "super", "stuff", "a lot of things"</i>	Social media <u>makes teenagers feel more worried</u> .	Social media exacerbates the anxiety teenagers already carry.
Passive voice ... be + past participle	Teenagers <u>always see</u> the perfect lives of other people on social media.	Teenagers are constantly exposed to polished images of other people's lives on social media.
Persuasive language (BOLD)	Social media is <u>bad</u> for students.	Social media is detrimental to teenagers' mental health. Fragmented attention makes deep reading almost impossible to sustain .
Linking words (<u>underlined</u>)	Social media is harmful. Students cannot concentrate.	Social media is harmful; <u>as a result</u> , students can no longer concentrate.
Avoid personal pronouns 'you'	You can see that phones are super bad for students' focus.	It is undeniable that over-reliance on smartphones undermines students' concentration.

5. Quick reference — linking words (underlined in the sample)	
Introduce and take a stance	In recent years, ... has become ubiquitous. I firmly believe that ... It is undeniable that ...
Open the first argument	First and foremost, ... The most serious consequence of ... is ...

Add an argument	Moreover, ... Worse still, ... Equally worrying is ...
Give an example	For instance, ... According to + [source] + ([year]), ... Consider what happens when ...
Concede, then rebut	Admittedly, ... Some may argue that ... However, ... What this overlooks is ...
Conclude and end	In conclusion, ... On balance, ... The answer is not to ... but to ...